

56 Modal verbs

Modal verbs are very common in English. They are used to talk about a variety of things, particularly possibilities, obligations, and deductions.

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56.1 USES OF MODAL VERBS

English has many modal verbs. Each modal verb can be used in several different contexts.

ABILITY

I **can** speak three languages.
I **can't** read Latin because it's too difficult.
I **couldn't** study it when I was at school.



PERMISSION

You **can** have more cake if you want.
You **may** take as much as you like.
Could I have another slice of cake?



REQUESTS

Can / **Could** you give me a ride home later?
Would you email James for me, please?
Will you lock up the office tonight?



OFFERS

Can I help you with those?
May I take one of those for you?
Shall I carry some of your bags?



SUGGESTIONS AND ADVICE

You **should** / **ought to** go to the doctor.
You **could** try the new medicine.



OBLIGATION

You **must** arrive on time for work.
You **must not** be late for work.



LOGICAL DEDUCTIONS

It **can't** be Jane because she's on vacation.
It **could** / **might** / **may** be Dave. I don't know.
It **must** be Tom, since nobody else ever calls.

